



Construction of a Noh mask

Noh masks must be light, as they are worn throughout an entire performance. Traditionally, each mask is carved out of a single piece of cypress wood.

Surface of the mask is painted with layers of gesso (primer) mixed with glue and then sanded down to give the mask its final shape

Black ink is used to outline the eyes and trace hair

Eyes have been gilded



Tea ceremony

A colored woodcut of a classic Edo era scene: geishas at a formal tea ceremony. *Cha-no-yu*, as it is called, was—and still is—considered a traditional art in Japan.

return they had to ensure that they did not neglect their farms, which meant they were forbidden to move away from the villages they occupied.

Below the farmers in terms of rights and restrictions were the artisans and craftsmen; merchants and shopkeepers were considered the lowest rank in this strict class structure. Commerce, however, developed in the expanding urban centers of Edo, Osaka, and Kyoto, and the merchant class made money trading and brokering, coming to enjoy a certain amount of financial power, which offset their “low class” status in this society.

Despite the oppressively rigid classification of society and the strict codes of behavior governing every aspect of life from clothing to social etiquette and even tea drinking, Japan also experienced a cultural renaissance in the 17th century.

Edo culture

The Edo Period produced much of what we recognize today as traditional Japanese culture. *Haiku*, the 17-syllable poem still in use today, was born; zen gardens, flower arranging, and the tea ceremony all came into their own; and *Noh* theater was transformed. *Noh* had its roots in the 11th century in the

provinces. It originally consisted of acrobatic and juggling displays, but the addition of operatic dance and recital transformed it into a highly stylized and symbolic drama. As with all other forms of cultural life in the Edo period, *Noh* theater was strictly governed and the lower classes were forbidden to learn the techniques of the art form. Kabuki, *ukiyo-e*, porcelain, and lacquerware all developed and thrived during this period. *Ukiyo-e*, or “pictures of the floating world,” was an art form that proved highly popular for its depictions of sensual courtesans, erotic prostitutes, and flashy kabuki actors. The *Ukiyo-e* style broadened from screen prints into wood-block prints to show scenes of Edo and landscapes, as typified by Hiroshige (see left). The genre also later proved influential to Western artists such as Vincent van Gogh, Claude Monet, Edgar Degas, and Gustav Klimt.

AFTER

The 18th and early 19th century in Japan were marked by severe famines, increasing social tensions, and repeated but unsuccessful attempts at political reform.

DECLINE OF THE SHOGUNATE

By the beginning of the 19th century, a growing number of Japanese saw the **shogunate system as inflexible and unresponsive** to new challenges **356–57** >>.

JAPAN'S MODERNIZATION

Japan was **forced to open** its borders by the US in 1854 and its **Westernization** began **356–57** >>. The Bank of Japan (including a modern mint) was established in 1882.

JAPANESE
COINS



Noh and Kabuki

There are four main categories of Noh masks, each representing a different Noh genre: god, demon, warrior, woman. Noh plays deal with a universal truth, displayed on stage in a kind of visual metaphor. The masks used in Noh theater use neutral expressions, which means that the actors have to use great skill to bring the characters “to life.” Pictured to the right are a 14th-century warrior mask and two Edo-period masks.

While Noh theater's restraint and elegance appealed to upper-class Japanese society, Kabuki theater, which was garish and bawdy, was embraced by the merchant class.



NOH WARRIOR



NOH DEMON



NOH WOMAN